Addendum: The October 22 Enrollment Review and the Community Analysis

Oct 20, 2026 · Emerson Christie

This is an addendum to the OSD 2026 Elementary Closure Proposal: Community Analysis (full analysis: emersoncodeprojects.github.io/olympia-closures). This addendum was written with AI assistance (Claude Opus 5.5). It addresses two questions raised since the analysis was published: what the district's Student Enrollment Review (the review) for the Oct. 22 board meeting means for the analysis, and whether the recruitment alternative rests on sound assumptions.

The review is consistent with the analysis. The review reports enrollment as annual average full-time equivalent (FTE), the measure the state uses for funding; the analysis uses headcount from the district's enrollment dashboard. At the 11 neighborhood elementary schools the two agree within 3 students, and the review's new transfer data strengthen the case for recruitment.

Recruitment does not depend on other savings. The recruitment paths in Table 4 assume no boundary changes, staffing changes or further cuts to close the forecast gap of about $0.4 million a year. Such savings would help, but recruitment reaches a 6% reserve without them.

Recruitment rests on assumptions of its own, and the district's data support them:

- Families already choose Olympia: approved transfers into OSD rose from 400 in 2022-23 to 719 in 2025-26, with, by the superintendent's account, only signs and social media behind them.
- The children are here: in-district births fell 10% between the birth years of the 2019 and 2026 kindergarten classes, while kindergarten enrollment fell 31%.
- There are students to win at every grade: every class grows as it moves up, from kindergarten through 9th grade.
- Olympia has enrolled many more students before: district headcount averaged 9,961 in 2019-20 and neighborhood elementary headcount was 4,031 in fall 2019, against 9,351 and 3,253 this fall.

Recruitment is comparable to closure on paper, without closure's risks. Under the adopted forecast, recruiting 50 students a year keeps the estimated fiscal health score above the 1.75 oversight line and reaches a 6% reserve by 2032-33. Closure gets there sooner on paper under the adopted forecast, but under the newest projection, with the October shortfall persisting, recruitment reaches 6% first at our midpoint savings (Table 4). Closure also carries a documented risk of further enrollment loss that is hard to undo, and at about 150 students lost, about half the average loss Pearman (2026) found after California closures, it saves less than the yearly gap. If recruitment falls short, the annual benchmarks show it in time for the board to act. The forecast does not describe a crisis: the gap is about 0.2% of spending, and under the adopted forecast the estimated score stays above 1.75 even with no action. The October shortfall makes starting recruitment now more urgent, but it does not make closure's risk necessary.

The district's figures match ours for these buildings

For the 11 neighborhood elementary schools, the district's October FTE and the dashboard's September headcount agree within 3 students at every school (Table 1). Full-day kindergarten and grades 1-5 count each student as 1.0 FTE, so the two measures cannot differ much in a neighborhood elementary school. The decline is also the same on either measure: neighborhood-school headcount fell 19.3% from fall 2019 to fall 2026 (4,031 to 3,253), and the district's K-5 FTE fell 19.1% (4,341 to 3,512).

Table 1. Neighborhood elementary schools: headcount and FTE, fall 2026

School	FTE, Oct. 2026	Headcount, Sept. 2026	Difference (FTE minus headcount)
Boston Harbor	166.0	166	0.0
Centennial (receiving)	384.5	382	+2.5
Garfield (receiving)	270.0	271	-1.0
Hansen (receiving)	271.7	271	+0.7
Lincoln	301.5	303	-1.5
LP Brown (proposed closure)	303.8	306	-2.2
Madison (proposed closure)	162.0	160	+2.0
McKenny (proposed closure)	277.0	275	+2.0
McLane	379.1	382	-2.9
Pioneer (receiving)	376.0	375	+1.0
Roosevelt (receiving)	363.0	362	+1.0
11 neighborhood schools	**3,254.6**	**3,253**	**+1.6**

Sources: OSD enrollment dashboard (September headcount); OSD Student Enrollment Review, Oct. 22, 2026 (October FTE).

The two measures differ in two places, and neither involves the schools proposed for closure (Table 2). ORLA counts 362 K-5 students but 257 FTE, consistent with part-time enrollment in its hybrid and online programs. The high schools count about 380 more students than FTE outside ORLA, close to the 438 Running Start students, who attend community college part- or full-time and whose funding goes to the college. Because both groups have grown since 2019, district-wide FTE has fallen faster than headcount (9.3% against 6.1%). Running Start also likely explains the drop in the ratio of 12th graders to the prior year's 11th graders that the analysis flagged as tentative. These details matter for district-wide FTE and help fill a gap the analysis noted; they do not, however, reflect what is happening at the neighborhood schools, where headcount and FTE agree.

Table 2. Where headcount and FTE differ, and why

Group	FTE	Headcount	Difference (FTE minus headcount)	Main reason
Neighborhood elementary, K-5 (fall 2026)	3,255	3,253	+2	Full-time students count as 1.0 FTE
ORLA, K-5 (fall 2026)	257	362	-105	Part-time enrollment in hybrid and online programs
High schools, 9-12 (2025-26 average)	3,062	3,458	-396	Mostly Running Start (438 students in 2025-26)
District K-12, change from 2019-20 to fall 2026	-9.3%	-6.1%		Growth in Running Start and part-time ORLA enrollment

Headcount from the OSD enrollment dashboard; FTE from the district review. District K-12: headcount 9,961 (2019-20 average) to 9,351 (September 2026); FTE 9,672 to 8,775 (October 2026).

Two measures for two questions

Headcount answers how many children a building must hold: desks, classrooms, lunch seating, and recess. It is the right measure for capacity and for any decision about closing buildings. FTE answers how much state funding the district receives, so it is the right measure for budget gains and losses. For neighborhood elementary schools the two coincide, so the analysis's capacity findings stand on either measure.

The review does not take the step that matters most for the budget: it never converts enrollment change into dollars. The analysis does. Recruited students are counted at half their revenue, about $7,400 each, on the assumption that most join existing classrooms at some added cost; this deliberately understates the value of recruitment and absorbs uncertainty over FTE and per-student funding. Students lost to closure are counted at the full $14,800 in state and levy revenue, because a departing student takes that revenue while the district's costs barely change.

The new shortfall points to recruitment, not irreversible decline

The review projects 2026-27 annual average enrollment of about 8,726 FTE, 64 below the 8,790 the budget assumed. At $10,400 to $14,800 per student, that is about $0.67-0.95 million less revenue this year, most or all of the budget's $720,000 surplus. If the shortfall carries into later years, the forecast gap of about $0.4 million a year would grow to about $1.1-1.4 million (estimates). Recovering those 64 students would restore the same amount; with the alternatives already costed in the analysis (about $0.7 million a year at the midpoint), that covers the larger gap. The figure is one month's projection; the annual average and the 2025-26 year-end financial report will settle it.

For balance: if the shortfall persists and none of it is recovered, it would delay the recruitment path's return to a 6% reserve by about three years, and closure's by even more: about eight years at our

midpoint savings (estimates; Table 4). The shortfall therefore shows an immediate need to recruit, not added pressure to close.

The evidence points to a recruitment gap rather than a shrinking pool of children. In-district births fell 10% between the birth years of the 2019 and 2026 kindergarten classes, while kindergarten enrollment fell 31%. In October, the elementary grades are already 56 FTE below the budgeted annual average, and elementary enrollment changes little during the year. The largest elementary miss is at Hansen (36 FTE below budget), a proposed receiving school; each of the three schools proposed for closure is within 10 FTE of budget. Closing schools does not recover families who never enroll, and a study of California closures found that closing districts lost about 288 students on average (Pearman, 2026), which would deepen the problem. A recruitment plan is designed to put the district on a path toward recovery and sustainability. Recruitment does not rule out closures later. It addresses the problem the district faces now, enrollment, and the annual enrollment and reserve benchmarks in the analysis give the board a clear test. If recruitment falls short of them, closure can return to the table with a year or more of measured results and a complete impact analysis behind it.

Families are choosing Olympia, and there are families to win back

The review's transfer data are the most useful new information (Table 3). They corroborate what the superintendent told the board on Oct. 8: approved transfers into OSD rose from 400 in 2022-23 to 719 in 2025-26, a gain of 319, of which 242 came over the two years to 2024-25 (642) and 77 in the last year. By the superintendent's account, that growth came from signs and social media, not from a dedicated, funded recruitment effort, which suggests how much a deliberate plan could add. More families from other districts choose Olympia each year, the elementary grades carry more than their share of that gain, and fewer enrolled students are leaving for private school or homeschool. The district's own grade table shows every class growing as it moves up, from kindergarten through 9th grade. Residents who leave go mainly to Tumwater (119), North Thurston (65), and Griffin (29), and 174 go to non-neighboring districts, a group the review does not break down and that may include statewide online programs.

Table 3. Transfers and withdrawals (district review)

Transfer measure	Figure
Students from other districts approved to attend OSD, 2025-26	719 (up 77 from 2024-25)
OSD residents approved to attend other districts, 2025-26	397 (up 15)
Net gain from transfers, 2025-26	+322
Elementary net gain (302 in, 131 out)	+171; 52% of the net gain with about 40% of enrollment
Out-of-district students as a share of enrollment	9% (914) in 2021-22 to 12% (1,154) in 2026-27
Confirmed withdrawals to private school or homeschool	Decreasing; 209 (2024) to 170 (2025) to 128 (2026)

Transfer measure	Figure
Growth of each class from 2025-26 to 2026-27 (district FTE)	K to 1st +20; 1st to 2nd +6; 2nd to 3rd +6; 3rd to 4th +9; 4th to 5th +14; 5th to 6th +12; 6th to 7th +16; 7th to 8th +3; 8th to 9th +176

Source: OSD Student Enrollment Review, Oct. 22, 2026. Transfer and withdrawal counts are headcount; class growth is FTE including ORLA.

Read together with the analysis, the review confirms the enrollment picture, adds evidence that recruitment works, and measures a shortfall that recruitment, not closure, is designed to recover.

Is recruitment alone financially sufficient?

Yes, under the district's adopted forecast. With no boundary changes, staffing changes, portables savings or further cuts, recruiting 50 more students a year than forecast keeps the reserve above 4% every year, keeps the estimated fiscal health score above the 1.75 oversight line, and reaches a 6% reserve by 2032-33 (Table 4). About 55 added students, counted at half their revenue, cover the $0.4 million yearly gap on their own. The recruitment paths in Table 4 assume no corrective actions to address the $0.4 million yearly gap, although taking corrective actions is recommended and would help. What we propose is a sketch, and these projections are estimates from the best data available to us. A real plan needs a real effort behind it: many of the assumptions in both this analysis and the 6883 report could be firmed up with the detail only the district can provide.

Table 4. Reserve, estimated fiscal health score, and the year each option reaches a 6% reserve (estimates). Assumes no corrective actions to address $0.4 million yearly gap.

Option	2027-28 reserve (score*)	2031-32 reserve (score*)	2035-36 reserve (score*)	Reaches 6%
1. Newest projection: the October 64-FTE shortfall persists				
Recruitment, 50 students a year	**3.6% (2.05)**	**3.7% (2.60)**	**6.4% (3.00)**	**2035-36**
Closure, our midpoint ($1.66M)	4.3% (2.60)	5.0% (2.60)	5.7% (2.60)	2038-39
2. Adopted forecast				
No action	4.1% (1.85)	3.0% (1.85)	2.2% (1.85)	Not by 2041
Recruitment, 30 students a year	4.2% (2.15)	4.5% (2.60)	6.4% (3.00)	2035-36
Recruitment, 50 students a year	**4.3% (2.15)**	**5.6% (2.60)**	**9.2% (3.00)**	**2032-33**
Closure, our midpoint ($1.66M)	4.9% (2.60)	6.8% (3.00)	8.5% (3.00)	2030-31
Closure, district low end ($2.24M)	5.2% (2.60)	8.2% (3.00)	10.7% (3.00)	2029-30

Option	2027-28 reserve (score*)	2031-32 reserve (score*)	2035-36 reserve (score*)	Reaches 6%
Closure, 6883 report ($3.14M)	5.7% (2.60)	10.2% (3.00)	14.1% (3.00)	2028-29
3. Stress tests: closure with enrollment loss (adopted forecast)				
Staged loss of 150 students (20% of those displaced)	5.0% (2.60)	4.9% (2.60)	4.5% (2.60)	Not by 2041
Staged loss of 288 students (Pearman's average)	4.7% (2.30)	1.2% (1.45)	-2.4% (1.05)	Not by 2041

**Fiscal scores are an interpolation from the district's Feb. 26, 2026 OSPI projections (its weights and the score bands its tables imply), not an OSPI calculation; days cash on hand is held at the district's projected 11 days, and scores near a band edge could be one step (0.35-0.40) higher or lower.*

Reserve as a share of prior-year spending, starting from the adopted 2026-27 ending balance of $8.41 million and the June forecast gaps; group 1 also subtracts the October shortfall (about $0.67 million a year, at the state-only $10,400 per FTE). Recruited students count at half of $14,800 and accumulate year to year (50, 100, 150 and so on above forecast). Stress tests phase in the loss over three years (50 or 96 students a year) and apply it to the district's savings less our cost adjustments; Pearman (2026) reports an average loss of 288 students (standard error 137). At about 150 students lost, closure saves less than the yearly gap.

Recruitment is the only path that conserves and builds revenue; closure and every other option work only by cutting cost. Under the adopted forecast, closure reaches 6% sooner on paper, but when it does depends on how much it actually saves. The two paths differ most in what happens when their assumptions fail (Table 5).

Table 5. What happens if each plan works, or does not

Question	Recruitment	Risk	Closure	Risk
If it works as planned	6% reserve by 2032-33; three schools stay open	Low	6% reserve by 2028-29 to 2030-31	Low
If it falls short	Reverts to no action: reserve at or above 3% through 2031-32, score near 1.85; closure returns with benchmark data	Low	A staged loss of about 150 students leaves closure saving less than the yearly gap: the reserve drifts down and never reaches 6%, and the schools are gone. At Pearman's average loss (288), the reserve falls below 3% by 2030-31	**High**

Question	Recruitment	Risk	Closure	Risk
Can it be undone?	Yes; closure stays available	Low	Hard to reverse; Seattle spent $48.1 million reopening closed schools	**High**
Space for students	Recruits fill existing empty seats	Low	Receiving schools at about 92-102% of functional capacity; no lunch, recess or class-size plan	Moderate
Effect on enrollment	Aims to grow it; transfers in rose about 100 a year with no plan	Low	The 6883 report assumes no loss; closing districts lost about 288 students on average in CA	**High**
If the 64-FTE shortfall persists	6% slips to about 2035-36, wins over closure	Moderate	6% at our midpoint slips to about 2038-39	Moderate

If recruitment falls short and the 64-FTE shortfall also persists, doing nothing would drop the reserve below 3% in 2028-29 and the score below 1.75 by 2030-31. The annual benchmarks would show that by fall 2027 or fall 2028, in time for the board to act.

Recruitment is also inexpensive to start. Our best estimate for a mostly community-led campaign, with the district covering mailers and a few posts (PTA open houses, volunteer ambassadors, donated printing), is about $10,000-24,000 a year. It pays for itself with 2-4 added students, against about $370,000 a year in net revenue from the first 50. The campaign would have to run every year. We elected not to carry its cost into Table 4 because closure also has its own transition costs (moving classrooms and programs, technology, communications to families), which the 6883 report does not cost either. However, including it would lower the recruitment rows' 2031-32 reserve by less than 0.1 percentage point (5.6% to about 5.5%), with no change to the fiscal score (estimates). A fuller effort with heavy district involvement is costed in Methods and calculations.

Both paths keep the district solvent on paper. Only closure carries a documented risk of further enrollment loss, which is the district's largest financial risk alongside the local levy that expires after 2028. Only recruitment produces the measured results the board would need to decide on closure later.

Methods and calculations

Every figure in this addendum is reproduced by `analysis/addendum_oct22.py` in the project repository, from the dashboard data and the district figures cited below. All results are estimates.

Headcount and FTE

Headcount is the September count from the OSD enrollment dashboard; FTE is the October 2026 figure in the district's Student Enrollment Review. Neighborhood schools: 3,253 headcount and 3,254.6 FTE (difference +1.6). ORLA K-5: 362 headcount and 257.4 FTE. High schools, 2025-26 average: 3,458 headcount (including ORLA) and 3,062 FTE; outside ORLA, 3,296 against about 2,913 FTE, a gap of about 383, close to the 438 Running Start students. Neighborhood K-5 headcount fell from 4,031 (September 2019) to 3,253 (September 2026), -19.3%; district K-5 FTE fell from 4,341 to 3,512, -19.1%.

Shortfall and per-student value

- Shortfall: 8,790 budgeted - 8,726 projected = 64 FTE. 64 x $10,400 (state only) = $0.67M; 64 x $14,800 (state and levy) = $0.95M.
- Gap if it persists: $0.41M + $0.67-0.95M = about $1.1-1.4M a year.
- Closure midpoint at the state-only value: our midpoint counts 63.5 lost students at $14,800; at $10,400 the loss is $0.28M smaller, so savings rise from $1.66M to about $1.94M.
- Students needed to cover the $0.41M gap: $0.41M / $7,400 = about 55 at half value (28 at full value).

Reserve model

Each year's ending balance = prior balance + net savings or recruitment revenue - forecast gap (- shortfall, in group 1).

- Starting balance: $8.41M, the adopted 2026-27 ending balance.
- Forecast gaps: $0.41M (2027-28), $0.37M (2028-29), $0.36M (2029-30 and each later year).
- Reserve % divides by prior-year spending: $195.67M, $202.93M, $207.89M and $212.52M for 2027-28 to 2030-31, then +2.2% a year.
- Recruitment adds 50 (or 30) students a year above forecast, cumulative, each at $7,400 (half of $14,800).
- Closure adds its net savings each year from 2027-28: $1.66M (our midpoint), $2.24M (district low end), $3.14M (6883 report).
- Group 1 subtracts the shortfall at the state-only value, $0.67M a year, including from the starting balance.
- Stress tests start from $2.60M (the $3.14M less upkeep $0.155M, custodial $0.305M and transportation $0.08M) and subtract lost students at $14,800, phased in over three years: 50 a year to 150, or 96 a year to 288.

Fiscal score interpolation

The score follows the OSPI model in the district's Feb. 26, 2026 projections: 40% fund balance to revenue, 35% expenditures to revenue, 15% days cash on hand, 10% years of deficit in the four-year

plan, each scored 0-4. Band edges are inferred from the district's scored years and are not published OSPI thresholds.

Table 6. Fiscal health score bands used in this addendum

Indicator	Weight	Bands used
Fund balance / revenue	40%	Below 0: 0; 0-2%: 1; 2-6%: 2; 6% and above: 3 (a 4 band exists but its edge is unknown, so it is not used)
Expenditures / revenue	35%	Below 100%: 4; 100-102%: 3; 102-104%: 2
Days cash on hand	15%	Held at the district's projected 11 days: 0
Deficit years in the four-year plan	10%	None: 4; one: 3; two: 2; three: 1

Applied to the district's own 2023-24 and 2024-25 figures, the bands return the district's scores exactly (2.60 and 2.15). Our fund balance is the total ending balance, not the unrestricted balance the district uses, and expenditures are revenue less each year's change in the balance. Scores near a band edge could be one step (0.35-0.40) higher or lower.

Recruitment cost

Table 7. Recruitment cost estimates, per year

Item	Assumption	District-backed	Community-led
February open houses, 11 schools	Materials, food, childcare, interpreters	$16,000-33,000	$3,000-9,000 (PTA-hosted, donated food and printing)
Teacher time	3-4 teachers x 3 hours per school at about $55 an hour (contract rate to be confirmed)	$5,000-10,000	Volunteers only
Social media	Targeted ads	$5,000-15,000	$500-2,000 (organic plus boosted posts)
Mailers	About $0.45 per piece (USPS Every Door Direct Mail), one or two mailings	About $4,500-9,000 (10,000 households, one or two mailings)	District-sent, same basis: about $4,500-9,000
Signage	Banners and yard signs	$3,000-6,000	$1,000-2,000
Translation	Policy 4218	$2,000-5,000	$1,000-2,000
Total		**About $35,000-78,000 (plus $45,000-75,000 for an optional 0.5 FTE lead)**	**About $10,000-24,000**

Break-even divides cost by $7,400 per student, rounded up: 5-11 students district-backed with existing staff, 11-21 with a part-time lead, and 2-4 community-led. Against the return, 50 added students bring about $370,000 a year at half value, so the community-led cost is about 3-6% of the first year's return and the fuller effort about 9-21%. These costs recur each year and are not subtracted in Table 4; subtracting them would lower the recruitment rows by 2031-32 by less than 0.1 percentage point (community-led) or about 0.1-0.2 percentage point (district-backed, existing staff); five years of $24,000 is $120,000 against about $217 million in spending.

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